
Concessions as Sponsorship · The Food Play

Internal, for BJ and Coach Jones. The smartest, easiest sponsorship lever at the Kingdom, and most people miss it. Pairs with `KOTS_SPONSOR_SYSTEM.md` (in-kind tier) and the concessions lead role in `../governance/KOTS_SCHOOL_COMMITMENT.md`.

The idea in one line

Stop chasing restaurants for cash. Let the right restaurants **feed the event** in exchange for exposure to hundreds of people over four days, and let them set their own offer. The food sells itself, the business gets a captive crowd, and the concession margin flows back to the program and the school.

Why this is the easy yes

A cash sponsorship asks a business to give money and get a logo. A food deal asks a business to do **what it already does**, put its product in front of hundreds of hungry families and players for four days, and walk away with new customers. That is a much smaller "no" to overcome. As the math gets framed: the coaches bring the kids in, the kids and families buy the food, the business gets the room. Everybody eats.

This is true business savvy: you do not walk in with a vague "want to sponsor us?" You walk in with a structured deal that already has the pieces in it, the way you would never price an antique without doing the research first. Come correct and it closes.

The one rule that makes or breaks it: feed who is actually eating

The customers are **teenage boys, 15 and 16 years old**, plus their families. Build the menu around what they actually want, not around who you happen to know.

- **Yes:** pizza, wings, burgers. Teenagers eat that every single day. It moves volume.
- **Be honest about the BBQ connection.** Coach may have a real relationship with a barbecue spot, and that relationship is worth keeping. But a 16-year-old choosing between wings and barbecue is taking the wings. Do not anchor the concession stand on the food the crowd will not buy. If the BBQ partner comes in, give them a **limited item or a single-day feature**, not the centerpiece.

Match the menu to the customer. That is the whole game.

The deal structure (what each side gives)

The restaurant provides:

- Product for the concession stand (donated or at deep cost) for some or all of the four days, OR
- An on-site activation (their own table/booth selling their product, with a revenue split to the event), OR
- A combination: they staff and sell, the event takes a cut.

The restaurant gets:

- Signage and PA shoutouts as the "Official [Pizza / Wings / Burgers] of the Kingdom."
 - Logo on the website and in the program.
 - Exposure to hundreds of local families across four days (real, repeat, in-person customers).
 - The right to set their own promotion: a coupon, a "show your ticket for 10% off," a QR code to their menu. **They decide the discount**, not us. That keeps it their marketing spend, not our ask.
-

Who to target (and in what order)

1. **Local pizza, wings, and burger spots first.** Independent owners who want neighborhood foot traffic. Fastest yes.
 2. **Local franchises of national chains.** A franchisee of a pizza or wings chain can often donate product for the exposure and write it off as marketing.
 3. **The warm connections, used correctly.** Coach's BBQ contact and any other relationships, slotted into the *right* role (a feature item, a single day, or a straight cash/in-kind sponsor) rather than the main menu.
 4. **Drinks and snacks** as a second wave (a beverage distributor, a local bakery for the families).
-

How it ties into the bigger picture

- The concession margin is real money. Last year it reportedly cleared around \$8,000, and the program saw none of it. Under the hosting partnership ([../governance/KOTS_REVENUE_SHARE_PROPOSAL.md](#)), a share of that comes back to Vanguard basketball. So a better food operation is not just feeding people, it is funding the program.
 - The **concessions lead** on the internal school committee owns this, so it is not one more thing on Coach's plate.
-

The 20-second pitch (for whoever works it)

"We host the Kingdom of the Sun, a 53-year national tournament. Four days, hundreds of families and players in the building, all of them hungry. We want [your pizza / your wings] to be the official food of the event. You put your product in front of the whole crowd, you run whatever offer you want to turn them into regulars, and we feature you all weekend. It is the easiest exposure you will buy all year, and it costs you product, not a check."